

EXHIBITION PROPOSAL

Ships of the Hanse: Evidence from the North Sea Floor

Hamburg Maritime Museum and Nordmeer Maritime University

Proposed exhibition period: February 2028 - January 2029

Submitted by: Prof. Dr. Gloria Gross | Dr. Frida Moe | 15.02.2026

1. Concept and Rationale

This proposal outlines a temporary exhibition that will bring the story of the North Frisian Medieval Wreck Survey to a broad public audience in Hamburg. The exhibition will present the medieval Hanseatic trade network through the material evidence recovered from Site NF-7, a 14th-century merchant vessel lying at 12-13 metres depth off the North Frisian coast. The exhibition will combine conserved finds, high-resolution photogrammetric reconstructions, and contextual historical material to tell the story of the vessel, its cargo, and the people who built and sailed it.

2. Core Themes

2.1 The Hanseatic trade world: The exhibition will situate the NF-7 vessel within the economic geography of the 14th-century North Sea, showing the routes, commodities, and cities that defined Hanseatic commerce. Hamburg's role as a hub of this network will be foregrounded as a connection point for visitors.

2.2 The archaeology: How does an underwater archaeologist find, document, and recover a wreck that has lain hidden for 600 years? The exhibition will demystify the methodology, from multibeam survey to controlled excavation, in a way that engages non-specialist visitors.

2.3 The sea as archive: The North Sea contains a physical record of human activity that no document archive can match. The exhibition will use the NF-7 finds to make the argument that the sea floor is a heritage resource of comparable importance to any land archive, and that its conservation is urgent.

3. Exhibits and Display

Gallery section	Key exhibit	Source
1. The North Sea in the 1300s	Scale model of Hanseatic trade routes	Museum collection
2. The Ship	Clinker plank NF7-014, wet storage display	NF-7 finds, conserved
3. The Cargo	Stoneware ceramics, barrel staves, hemp rope	NF-7 finds, conserved
4. Finding the Wreck	Multibeam sonar mosaic, interactive screen	NMU data
5. The Science	Dendrochronology panel, conservation lab replica	Caledonia/HMM
6. Climate and the Future	Sea-level projection interactive	NMU climate research

4. Frisian Community Partnership

The exhibition will include a dedicated panel presenting Frisian oral history and place name knowledge as a complementary historical source alongside the archaeological evidence. This panel

has been developed in consultation with Ailo Reimer and reflects the genuine partnership model on which the survey project is based. Community representatives will be invited to the opening and to a public lecture accompanying the exhibition.

5. Budget Estimate

Item	Estimated cost (EUR)
Exhibition design and build	180000
Conserved find display cases and mounts	45000
Interactive digital elements	38000
Photography and reproduction rights	12000
Community partnership and translation	8500
Marketing and printed materials	22000
Education programme development	15000
Contingency (10%)	32050
Total	352550